

CHECKLIST

HubSpot CRM Setup Checklist

A practical pre-launch checklist for contacts, data structure, lifecycle stages, pipelines, permissions, automation foundations, integrations, and reporting readiness.

Use this before relying on a CRM operationally.

Work from top to bottom, document decisions, and do not mark an item complete until the underlying configuration has been tested.

DOCUMENT CONTROL

Business / account name:

Prepared by:

CRM owner:

Review date:

How to use the checklist

- ☐ **1. Design before configuration**
Define the data model, ownership rules, pipeline logic, and reporting requirements before building automations.
- ☐ **2. Configure in controlled passes**
Make changes in logical groups so each layer can be tested independently.
- ☐ **3. Test with representative records**
Use realistic contacts, companies, deals, tickets, and edge cases. Verify both the happy path and failure path.
- ☐ **4. Document exceptions**
Record anything that requires manual review, custom code, integration limits, or plan-dependent features.

1. CRM foundation and data model

Build the structure that keeps records consistent before adding sophisticated automation.

ACCOUNT AND OBJECT FOUNDATION

- ☐ **Define the CRM operating purpose**
Document the primary business processes the CRM must support: marketing, sales, service, or a defined combination.
- ☐ **Confirm required CRM objects**
Identify which objects are actually needed: contacts, companies, deals, tickets, and any custom objects available to the account.
- ☐ **Define record ownership**
Decide who owns each record type, how ownership is assigned, and what happens when an owner leaves or a record is reassigned.
- ☐ **Map associations**
Document the intended relationship between people, companies, deals, tickets, and other records so reporting and automation have a reliable structure.
- ☐ **Define source-of-truth systems**
For every important field, identify whether HubSpot, an ecommerce platform, ERP, website form, calendar, or another system is authoritative.

CONTACT AND COMPANY DATA

- ☐ **Standardize contact fields**
Agree on required fields, naming conventions, valid values, and formatting for email, phone, job title, company, location, and other key attributes.
- ☐ **Define minimum viable record**
Specify the minimum information needed before a new contact or company is considered usable by marketing or sales.
- ☐ **Document duplicate policy**
Define matching rules, duplicate review ownership, merge standards, and how imported records are checked before they enter the CRM.
- ☐ **Define lifecycle terminology**
Use a documented lifecycle model that separates marketing status, sales progress, and customer status where those concepts differ.

Design note

A CRM becomes difficult to govern when the same business concept is represented by several competing properties. Prefer one authoritative field per business concept and document what each property means.

2. Properties, lifecycle stages, and pipelines

The goal is not to create more fields. The goal is to create fields and stages that are understandable, reportable, and operationally useful.

PROPERTIES AND DATA DICTIONARY

- ☐ **Inventory properties**
Export or document the important properties currently used by forms, lists, workflows, reports, integrations, and teams.
- ☐ **Remove or archive clutter**
Identify unused, duplicate, ambiguous, or obsolete properties and define a cleanup path before adding more.
- ☐ **Set field standards**
Define the intended data type, allowed values, format, requiredness, and owner for important custom properties.
- ☐ **Document calculated / derived fields**
Record which values are derived automatically, what inputs they rely on, and where users should not manually overwrite them.
- ☐ **Create a data dictionary**
Keep a shared definition for business-critical properties so marketing, sales, and service use the same terminology.

LIFECYCLE AND SALES PROCESS

- ☐ **Define lifecycle stages**
Confirm what each lifecycle stage means, when a record enters it, what qualifies it to advance, and which process owns the transition.
- ☐ **Define pipeline stages**
For each deal or operational pipeline, document stage entry criteria, exit criteria, required information, owner, and expected next action.
- ☐ **Separate lifecycle from pipeline**
Do not use a pipeline stage as a substitute for a lifecycle stage when the two concepts represent different business dimensions.
- ☐ **Document stage-change automation**
Identify which stage changes should trigger tasks, notifications, emails, assignment, or reporting updates.
- ☐ **Test stage transitions**
Use sample records to verify that manual edits, integrations, and automations do not create impossible or contradictory states.

Quick control table

AREA	CHECK	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Lifecycle stage	Definition + transition criteria	Teams use the same meaning and automation is predictable.
Pipeline stage	Entry / exit rules	A record cannot sit indefinitely without an expected next action.
Property	Purpose + owner + valid values	Field meaning remains clear six months later.

3. Permissions, teams, imports, and data quality

Access controls and data hygiene are operational foundations, not administrative afterthoughts.

USER ACCESS AND GOVERNANCE

- ☐ **Inventory users and roles**
List active users, roles, teams, and functional responsibilities. Remove stale users and unnecessary access.
- ☐ **Set record access deliberately**
Define who can view, create, edit, delete, merge, export, and administer each relevant record type.
- ☐ **Protect sensitive properties**
Identify properties that require tighter visibility or editing controls and document the reason.
- ☐ **Restrict high-impact settings**
Limit access to integrations, automation, pipelines, imports, exports, and other settings that can affect many records.
- ☐ **Document ownership changes**
Define what happens to records, tasks, sequences, and notifications when a user changes roles or leaves.

IMPORTS, DEDUPLICATION, AND DATA QUALITY

- ☐ **Back up source data**
Preserve the original export or source dataset before a large migration or cleanup.
- ☐ **Map fields before importing**
Create a source-to-destination mapping and identify fields that require transformation or normalization.
- ☐ **Test a small import**
Validate a representative sample before importing a large dataset.
- ☐ **Check duplicates after import**
Review duplicate behavior and association quality, not just whether the import completed successfully.
- ☐ **Create quality checks**
Choose a small set of recurring checks: missing owner, missing email, invalid lifecycle state, stale records, duplicate records, and other business-specific exceptions.

Data quality acceptance test

AREA	CHECK	WHAT GOOD LOOKS LIKE
Required data	Key fields populated	Core workflows and reports have the information they require.
Ownership	Correct owner/team	Every operational record has an accountable owner.
Associations	Correct relationships	Contact/company/deal/ticket relationships support reporting.
Duplicates	No unexpected duplicates	Known duplicates are merged or intentionally retained.

4. Automation and reporting foundations

Automation is safest when the data model, triggers, suppression rules, and success measures are defined first.

WORKFLOW FOUNDATION

- ☐ **Name workflows consistently**
Use a naming convention that identifies business process, object, stage, and purpose.
- ☐ **Define enrollment logic**
Specify exactly who or what should enter the process and whether enrollment is filter-based, event-based, scheduled, webhook-driven, or manual.
- ☐ **Plan re-enrollment intentionally**
Decide whether a record should be allowed to enter again and document the exact conditions that justify it.
- ☐ **Define unenrollment / suppression**
Specify stop conditions, suppression audiences, completed-goal conditions, and other exclusions before activation.
- ☐ **Map actions and timing**
Document sends, property updates, tasks, delays, branches, record assignments, and notifications in sequence.
- ☐ **Define failure handling**
Identify what happens when a required field is missing, an integration fails, a branch has no match, or a human does not act.

REPORTING AND INTEGRATIONS

- ☐ **Define source attribution**
Document how campaign, form, ad, website, referral, and offline sources are captured and reconciled.
- ☐ **Build operational reports**
Create reports for queue health, ownership, lifecycle movement, conversion, stalled records, and workflow exceptions.
- ☐ **Build outcome reports**
Define the business outcomes the CRM must explain: leads, opportunities, revenue, retention, service volume, or another KPI.
- ☐ **Test integrations**
Validate create, update, sync, and error behaviors for every critical integration.
- ☐ **Document integration ownership**
Name the system owner and escalation path for each connected platform.

HubSpot workflow settings currently include enrollment criteria, re-enrollment, unenrollment conditions, suppression controls, and action sequencing. Configure these deliberately rather than assuming a record will enter or leave a workflow exactly once. Source: HubSpot Knowledge Base, current workflow documentation (September 2026).

5. Pre-launch QA and ongoing governance

Do not consider the CRM ready because the configuration exists. Consider it ready when representative scenarios produce the intended result.

PRE-LAUNCH TESTING

- ☐ **Test new-record path**
Create a new record and verify default values, ownership, lifecycle state, associations, and downstream automation.
- ☐ **Test existing-record path**
Verify how existing records behave when they newly satisfy conditions.
- ☐ **Test edge cases**
Use missing data, duplicate data, boundary values, unexpected stage changes, and reassignment scenarios.
- ☐ **Test suppression**
Confirm that excluded records do not receive unintended communications or actions.
- ☐ **Test re-entry**
Where re-enrollment is enabled, prove that the record can re-enter only under the intended conditions.
- ☐ **Test human handoff**
Confirm tasks, notifications, queues, ownership changes, and escalation paths appear where expected.
- ☐ **Verify reporting**
Confirm that test records appear correctly in operational and outcome reports, then remove or label test data.

ONGOING GOVERNANCE

- ☐ **Assign a CRM owner**
One person or role is responsible for the integrity of the configuration and the change process.
- ☐ **Schedule periodic reviews**
Review properties, workflows, pipelines, integrations, users, permissions, and reports at a defined cadence.
- ☐ **Maintain change records**
Record significant configuration changes, why they were made, who approved them, and how they were tested.
- ☐ **Monitor exceptions**
Track failed syncs, workflow errors, stale records, unassigned records, and other exception conditions.
- ☐ **Retire dead automation**
Deactivate or replace workflows that no longer serve an active business process.

Launch decision

READY	Core data model is documented; critical scenarios pass; ownership is clear; suppression and exception handling are tested; reporting is usable.
HOLD	A critical path is untested, ownership is ambiguous, data quality is unreliable, or automation can produce unintended customer-facing actions.

6. Quick reference and source notes

Use the links below to confirm current HubSpot behavior before making plan-dependent or product-specific configuration decisions.

HUBSPOT KNOWLEDGE BASE - CURRENT WORKFLOW REFERENCES

REFERENCE	URL / PURPOSE
Create workflows	https://knowledge.hubspot.com/workflows/create-workflows Current workflow creation, enrollment triggers, re-enrollment, unenrollment, and action configuration.
Set workflow enrollment triggers	https://knowledge.hubspot.com/workflows/set-your-workflow-enrollment-triggers Current enrollment trigger types and requirements.
Manage workflow enrollment settings	https://knowledge.hubspot.com/workflows/manage-workflow-enrollment-settings Current re-enrollment, unenrollment, suppression, and enrollment settings.
Add re-enrollment triggers	https://knowledge.hubspot.com/workflows/add-re-enrollment-triggers-to-a-workflow Current re-enrollment rules and supported trigger behavior.
Create and customize lifecycle stages	https://knowledge.hubspot.com/object-settings/create-and-customize-lifecycle-stages Current lifecycle-stage configuration guidance.
Assign access to records	https://knowledge.hubspot.com/records/assign-access-to-records Current user and record-access controls.

Note on product availability

HubSpot functionality, permissions, and subscription requirements can vary by product and plan. This checklist is intended as an operational planning tool; verify the current account UI and subscription before treating any feature as available.

Pulse Analytics Group LLC designed this checklist to support practical CRM setup and governance. It is not an official HubSpot document and does not replace HubSpot product documentation.